Eventually, as the war came home – spilling over what was being called the 'AfPak Border' into mainland Pakistan – it became our struggle. But what happened to the Lankan team that afternoon in Lahore made it pretty clear to Moin bhai and me that there would not be much international cricket in Pakistan, not anytime soon. Indeed, Pakistan was declared unsafe for several years. But the Lahore attack, in our cultural capital in the heartland of Punjab, on our treasured tradition of cricket, really broke us all down.

Some folks might disagree, but I don't think any other nation has given up more to fight terror than Pakistan. In the last couple of decades, no nation has spent more blood and money in this fight than Pakistan. Over 80,000 casualties sustained. Over 130 billion dollars spent. But what the official numbers won't tell you is the toll on our national polity and psyche. Frankly, we've done a lot more than our fair share. Pakistan has done most of the heavy lifting to fight this ongoing war and it continues to do so.

Today, when I look back, I can't believe that amidst all that isolation which followed the Lankan attack, Pakistan cricket has managed to do rather well despite not playing at home for almost a decade. The team's resilience was evident soon after the attack.

Less than two months after Lahore, we went to Dubai to play Australia. Personally, I did well in the series – some useful cameos down the order along with one six-wicket haul. We would lose the series, though. Still, delivering individually against the Aussies is always good for one's confidence. But in the wake of Lahore, even though we lost the series, this was confidence we really needed. We would use that momentum soon after, in June that year, to play the World T20 in England and win the final comprehensively at Lord's. A few months earlier, Pakistan had felt deeply ashamed, letting harm come to its guests, the Lankans. But on the day of that final, we stood tall and proud at Lord's, this time beating the Lankans in a game, fair and square.

Believe it or not, when the tournament began, the Pakistan team was written off and not even considered a contender for the title. After the attacks in Lahore, it was clear that no cricket-playing side would express interest in touring Pakistan. Moreover, we had recently lost to the Aussies. In the early stages of the championship, we didn't do much to beat this impression and lost to England and Sri Lanka in the group stages.

But after taking a beating in the initial round, there was no looking back. Some of the things that transpired for Pakistan had to do with changes I underwent myself.

Personally, I tried to be responsible. I don't know where the motivation came from but I truly wanted things to change. Moreover, everybody had had enough of Afridi the Terrible. Afridi the Undependable. Afridi the Bludgeoner. Afridi the Hitter or Misser.

Something had to change.

The semi-final against the Proteas was an indication of what I was trying to do to transform; I didn't hit even a single six in 45 balls, but I still reached the half-century mark. I took on additional responsibility and played a very 'un-Afridi'-like innings (I'd had a 50s' drought for years). And throughout the tournament, I delivered with the ball as well – I hit the stumps seven times while bowling and had an economy rate of under six.

You could say that anger and being cornered on the world stage helped me come back to form. Also, the timing was right. The mental approach was the correct one. The attack on the Lankan team had given us the impetus to fix things. Winning the World T20 was a benchmark we wanted to set. Not united by much as a unit, this time, after the Lahore attack, we all had a